WITH OVER 300 MILLION COPIES SOLD IN 115 COUNTRIES IN 48 LANGUAGES, Jeffrey Archer holds the distinction of being one of the most popular authors in the world, India being one of his biggest markets. Ask him why he thinks he has such a loyal readership in India and he remarks, "Leading authors ask me, 'why are you so popular in India, Jeffrey?' Well, you people are an aspirational, hard-working race. You all think you're Abel. You're all fighting to get to the top, which I admire so much." Archer's love for cricket probably helped too and he counts V.V.S. Laxman and Rahul Dravid among his fans. "Sunil Gavaskar is an old friend. The Nawab of Pataudi and I were at Oxford together and remained friends. Indeed, he once held a dinner in my honour in Delhi," he recounts.

At 85 years of age, Archer is penning his final novel. He has done a couple of drafts so far and expects to finish it sometime before Christmas. The idea for the novel came to him six years ago when he was reading a speech by Adolf Hitler. "Then I read Winston Churchill's response to it and realised that WWII could have ended on September 15, 1941. Three books had been written about what happened that day, all by distinguished historians but no one had tackled the subject as a novel. It has been the biggest challenge of my life," he says. He's not modest about it either. "I think it's the best thing I've ever done—even better than *Kane and Abel*!" Considering the 1979 novel is counted among the world's top 100 best-selling books, that is a tall claim indeed.

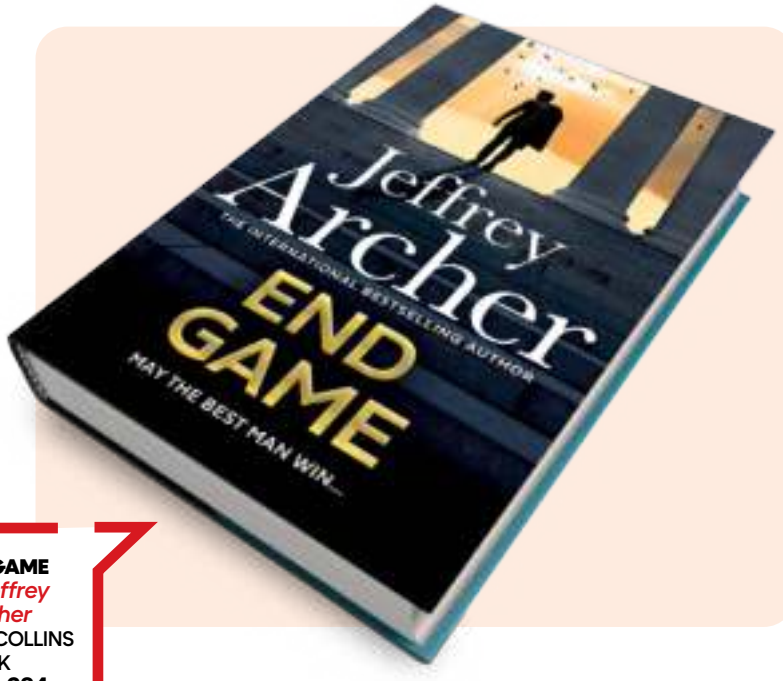
However, before he does that, there's one more 'final' act, so to speak. He has recently released *End Game*, the conclusive novel of the William Warwick books (2019-2025). The protagonist of the popular series first appeared as a detective in *The Clifton Chronicles* (2011-2017) and Archer recalls fans writing to him to know more about Warwick. "I was 77 years old when I wrote the first novel featuring him and had no idea there would be eight volumes taking me right through to the age of 85," he chuckles.

Along with him, the readers have seen Warwick rise up from the ranks to become a Commander in Scotland Yard. His latest release is set against the backdrop of the London Olympics of 2012. "I met Commander Bob Broadhurst, who was in charge of the Olympic security, and asked him if anything at the games had gone wrong. He told me about 13 things that went wrong which the public are not aware of—two of them, which the security forces stopped, would have made the front page in every country on earth! All 13 of those incidents are in the book, plus nine of my own imagination and it is up to the reader to decide which of them were real and which were not," he reveals.

Archer's initiation into the world of writing was not exactly smooth. When he sat down to write his first novel, *Not a Penny More, Not a Penny Less,* in 1975, he was in an incredible financial crisis, with debts amounting to £400,000. Twelve publishers turned his novel down, but the 13th gave him a £3,000 advance, and the book sold 3,000 copies. In 1979, he published his masterpiece *Kane and Abel* which became a global bestseller, enabling him to enjoy the next five decades of writing.

Yet another hurdle came his way when he was imprisoned for two years from 2001 to 2003 following charges of perjury over a 1987 libel case. During his time there, Archer wrote a three-volume prison diary series—*Hell, Purgatory* and *Heaven*. Looking back upon his time there, Archer shares that he is lucky to have a strong family and many good friends. "And the readers remained absolutely loyal!" he remarks.

On the subject of readers, Indians certainly love the storyteller! At the Jaipur Literature Festival in 2019, more than 8,000 people turned up to listen to him speak. "I thought some pop star was coming and they were waiting for him!" he guffaws. His books have been the subject of many an unauthorised adaptation, a situation prompting



END GAME
by Jeffrey Archer
HARPERCOLLINS UK
₹499; 384 pages